



DELHI | Talking the Walk

There may be a huge trust deficit but this time it looks like Indo-Pak diplomacy is breaking all the rules. Abandoning diplomatic protocol, the two foreign ministers picked up their phones on May 11 to decide the dates for what is being seen as a new template for bilateral talks between the two argumentative South Asian cousins. External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna will travel to Pakistan for talks with his counterpart S.M. Qureshi. This will be the first structured dialogue between India and Pakistan after 26/11. While Pakistan has pushed for an early date, Krishna has told Qureshi that this may not be the best time as it comes just after 26/11 terrorist Ajmal Amir Kasab's death sentence. The July 15 talks will include terrorism, water management and Kashmir. Before the talks, Home Minister P. Chidambaram is going to travel to the SAARC home minister's meet scheduled in Islamabad on June 26. That is where the two foreign secretaries will meet on the sidelines to fix the July talks agenda. It took three months to fix the Thimpu talks between the two prime ministers. Yet India knows that for any talks to be meaningful, Pakistan will have to address India's concerns on terrorism without which it will be just another futile exercise. Going by the past record between the two neighbours, even an agreement on dates though is progress.

KRISHNA AND QURESHI WILL MEET IN JULY TO RESTART THE DIALOGUE BETWEEN INDIA AND PAKISTAN

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high-level rounds of talks have been held between India and Pakistan after the Mumbai attacks of November 26, 2008.

by Saurabh Shukla